

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 12

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: An apprentice baker describes the morning she burned her first batch of loaves during a busy Saturday shift.

1

The oven timer was set for forty-two minutes, and I remember being proud of that — proud that I had remembered the odd number, proud that I had measured the salt by weight rather than by the careless pinch of my first week. It was my third Saturday at the bakery, and Mr Halim had finally allowed me to shape and bake a batch of country loaves on my own. Twelve of them, lined up on the cooling rack of my imagination, golden and humming with steam. I would carry them out to the front shelves myself, and the regulars would notice, and Mr Halim would nod once, which from him meant a great deal.

2

That was the plan. What actually happened was that, at minute twenty-six, a delivery van arrived at the back door with three trays of rye flour we had not been expecting, and I went out to sign for it. The driver wanted to chat. Somebody else's phone was ringing inside the kitchen. The front bell rang twice, then three times. By the time I returned to my station and remembered — with a small cold drop somewhere behind my breastbone — that the timer should have gone off ten minutes ago, the air around the oven had already begun to smell, very faintly, of something gone wrong.

3

I opened the door. The smell rolled out first, thick and acrid, and then I saw them: twelve loaves the colour of charcoal, their crusts cracked and weeping a dark, bitter syrup. The kitchen, which had been full of the soft, hopeful noise of a busy Saturday, went strangely quiet. I could hear my own breathing. I could hear, somewhere far away, the front bell ring again.

4

There is a particular kind of shame that comes when you have ruined something that other people were counting on. It is heavier than the shame of failing a test, because a test punishes only you. I stood in front of the open oven and felt the heat on my face, and I thought, quite seriously, about taking off my

apron and walking out of the back door and never coming in again. I thought about the regulars who would arrive at eleven and find the country-loaf shelf empty. I thought about Mr Halim, who had trusted me. The tears, when they came, were hot and useless.

5

He must have smelled the smoke from the front, because he came through the swinging door without hurrying, wiped his hands on his apron, and looked at the oven for what felt like a long time before he looked at me. I waited for him to be angry. I had rehearsed, in those few seconds, all the ways he might be angry, and I had decided that I would not argue with any of them. Instead he said, very quietly, “Well. Open the back door, please. Let the smoke out.”

6

That was all, at first. He took out the tray with a practised swing, slid the ruined loaves into the compost bin, and set the tray on the bench to cool. Then he turned to me and said, in the same level voice, “You will need to weigh out another twelve. The dough is in the cold room. I will help you shape them. We have an hour, perhaps a little less.” He paused. “And next time, my dear, you take the timer with you when you leave the kitchen. Even into the yard. Even into the street. The timer is the only friend a baker has who never lies.”

7

We worked in near silence after that, side by side, his hands faster than mine but never impatient. He showed me, without saying so, how to fold the dough more firmly at the seam, how to dust the proving cloth so that nothing stuck. When the second batch went into the oven, he set his own watch on the bench beside the timer and tapped it twice with one floury finger. He did not need to explain.

8

The second batch came out at twenty past eleven, golden, humming with steam, exactly the loaves I had imagined that morning. The regulars came. The shelves filled. Nobody, except the two of us and the compost bin, ever knew what had happened. That night, walking home through the wet streets, I discovered something I had not expected. I was not, as I had feared, finished with bread. I was, in some quiet way I could not yet name, only just beginning.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says she was proud of measuring the salt “by weight rather than by the careless pinch of my first week.” What does this comparison tell us about how she has changed since she started at the bakery? [2]

2. The narrator describes the loaves as “lined up on the cooling rack of my imagination.” What does this phrase suggest about her state of mind at the start of the shift? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show why the narrator was distracted from her baking. [2]

4. The narrator describes “a small cold drop somewhere behind my breastbone.” Explain what this phrase suggests about her feelings at this moment. [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says the crusts of the loaves were “weeping a dark, bitter syrup.” Explain how this language makes the ruined loaves seem more dramatic. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says that the shame of ruining the loaves “is heavier than the shame of failing a test, because a test punishes only you.”

(a) Explain, in your own words, why she feels this shame is heavier. [1]

(b) What does her thought of “taking off my apron and walking out of the back door” tell us about her emotional state? [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. Mr Halim looked at the oven “for what felt like a long time before he looked at me.” Explain what this delay suggests about Mr Halim, and what effect it has on the narrator. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. Mr Halim says that “the timer is the only friend a baker has who never lies.” What is **effective** about describing a kitchen timer as a “friend”? [2]

9. Based on Paragraph 6, what **impression** do you get of Mr Halim as a teacher? Support your answer with **one** detail from the paragraph. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. Mr Halim “tapped” the watch on the bench “twice with one floury finger” and “did not need to explain.” What does this small gesture communicate to the narrator? [1]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on why public libraries still matter in the digital age.****1**

The public library is, by most reasonable measures, a strange institution to have survived into the twenty-first century. It lends books for nothing, charges no admission, asks no proof of purpose, and stays open even on days when the rain keeps everyone else away. In an age that prizes efficiency and pay-per-use, the library is almost defiantly inefficient: a building of paper and quiet, paid for by the public purse, in the middle of a city of glowing screens. And yet, very nearly everywhere it exists, it is one of the most heavily used civic spaces a country owns.

2

This is not, as is sometimes assumed, because people are still coming for the books. They are — circulation figures across most national systems remain remarkably steady — but they are also coming for a great many other things. Walk into any branch library on a weekday morning and you will see job-seekers using the free computers to update their CVs; retirees attending a Mandarin class in the meeting room; new parents at a singing session for their babies; teenagers, hunched over revision notes, who could not study at home for reasons they would rather not explain. The library has, almost unnoticed, become a kind of universal third place — neither home nor workplace, but somewhere a person may simply **be**, on terms of their own choosing.

3

None of this is accidental. Modern librarians have, over the past two decades, quietly redesigned their service around a question that the early Victorian founders never quite had to ask: what is a library **for**, in a world where information itself is no longer scarce? The answer, increasingly, is that a library is for the things that **information** cannot supply on its own — guidance, trust, equipment, space, and time. A search engine can give you ten thousand articles on retraining as a nurse. A librarian, sitting beside you, can help you decide which two of them to actually read.

4

The case for libraries is sharpest in the matter of the digital divide. It is fashionable, in policy circles, to speak as though every household now has fast broadband, a reliable laptop, and an adult who knows how to use them. The evidence says otherwise. A 2023 survey by the British charity Good Things Foundation found that roughly one in seven adults in the United Kingdom either could not afford home internet or did not feel confident using it for essential tasks such as booking a doctor's appointment or applying for housing. For these households — and they are not a small minority — the library is not a luxury. It is, quite literally, the only place in the neighbourhood where the rent application can be filled in, the prescription renewed, and the school place accepted, without paying for the privilege.

5

And yet, in the same two decades, library budgets in most wealthy countries have shrunk. In England, more than 800 public libraries have closed since 2010, and many of those that remain rely on unpaid volunteers to keep their doors open. In Singapore, the system has fared rather better, but even here the small neighbourhood branches face quiet pressure from rising rents and shifting priorities. The arithmetic of council budgets is unforgiving: a library that issues fewer paper books each year looks, on a spreadsheet, like a service in decline, even when the same building is busier with people than it has ever been. What the spreadsheet cannot capture is the value of the toddler who first heard a story read aloud in that room, or the unemployed forty-year-old who got the job because someone at the desk fixed his CV.

6

There is a wider point, too, about what disappears when a library closes. It is not merely the books, which can be borrowed elsewhere or bought online by those who can afford to. It is the unspoken civic promise

that a society, however unequal in other respects, has set aside at least one room in every neighbourhood where wealth, age and purpose do not determine welcome. Take that room away, and the divide that already exists between those with private studies and those with crowded flats becomes harder, not easier, to cross. A society that closes its libraries is not, in any meaningful sense, saving money; it is shifting a cost — quietly, and onto the people least able to bear it.

7

None of this is an argument for nostalgia. Libraries must continue to change, and most are doing so: lending laptops, hosting coding clubs, opening late on weekday evenings, partnering with health services to host clinics for the lonely. But the change needs investment, not merely encouragement, and investment in turn needs a public willing to defend the service from each new round of cuts. The library has survived for two centuries because, again and again, ordinary citizens have insisted that it should. Whether it survives the next one will depend, in the end, on whether we — busy, well-connected, often online — remember to insist again.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer calls the public library “almost defiantly inefficient.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the library’s relationship with modern values. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** groups of people, other than book borrowers, who now use the library. [2]

14. The writer describes the library as “a kind of universal third place.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says that what a library is now **for** is “the things that **information** cannot supply on its own.” Explain, in your own words, what these things are, using details from Paragraph 3. [2]

16. Why does the writer use **italics** on the word “for” in the second sentence of Paragraph 3? [1]

From Paragraph 4

17. Why does the writer say it is “fashionable, in policy circles” to assume that every household has good internet access? What is his **attitude** to that assumption? [2]

18. Give **two** essential tasks mentioned in Paragraph 4 that some adults rely on the library to help them complete. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer says that “the arithmetic of council budgets is unforgiving.” Explain how the language of this sentence makes budget decisions seem cold or impersonal. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer claims that a society that closes its libraries is not “saving money” but “shifting a cost — quietly, and onto the people least able to bear it.” Explain, in your own words, what he means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by describing the public as “busy, well-connected, often online.” Why does he choose these three words to describe the reader at this point? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the modern roles that public libraries now play** and **the pressures that threaten their survival**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Public libraries today serve their communities in many ways, but ...

— END OF PAPER —